

The world of reptiles

Reptiles are mainly egg-laying animals that have a tough skin covered in scales. They live on land and in water.

The reptile groups

There are four main groups of reptiles.



The tortoise family: these reptiles all have a shell over their bodies.



Snakes and lizards: the majority of reptiles fall into this group.



The crocodile family: this group are the giants of the reptile world.



Tuataras: these reptiles are very rare and look a bit like lizards.

Reptiles can eat huge meals, then go without food for days.

Most reptiles, like this lizard, swing their bodies from side to side when walking.

Eating habits

Most reptiles are meat-eaters, apart from tortoises, which move too slowly to catch fast-moving prey.

Lizards, such as this gecko, can eat half their own weight in insects in one night.

All reptiles shed their skin from time to time.

Flying gecko

Hot and cold

Reptiles have scales, which can control how much water they lose through their skin. This means they can live in dry places. They are, however, cold-blooded, and so rely on the climate to keep their bodies warm.

European eyed lizard

Reptile babies

Nearly all reptiles lay eggs, which hatch into miniature versions of their parents. However, a few, such as this slow worm, give birth to live young.



This lizard, which lives in the desert, basks on rocks to warm up its body.